

Session 26: Jacob's Last Request

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors highlight Yaaqov's request to be buried in the cave in the field of Makpelah where his parents and grandparents are buried.
- The Hebrew words for "cave" (*me'arah*) and "Makpelah," roughly translating to "naked" and "pair," link this burial site to the garden of Eden.

Section 3: Genesis 49:29-50:26

Genesis 49:29- 50:14

49:29-33

Ya'akov Commands His Sons To Bury Him in Canaan

- 49:29-30 "And he commanded them: 'Bury me in the cave in the field of Makpelah ... in the land of Canaan, that Avraham purchased from Ephron the Hittite.'"
- 49:33 "And Ya'akov died and was gathered to his people"

50:1-11

- a - 50:1-3 70 days of weeping over Ya'akov's death + 40 days of embalming his body
- b - 50:4-6 Yoseph requests to go up to Canaan to bury his father in Canaan
- b' - 50:7-9 Yoseph goes up with Pharaoh's house to bury his father in Canaan
- a' - 50:10-11 Seven days of weeping at the threshing floor of the thorn

50:12-14

Ya'akov's Sons Bury Their Father

- "And his sons did as they were commanded, they carried him to the land of Canaan and buried him in the cave of the field of Makpelah ... which Avraham purchased from Ephron the Hittite."

Genesis 50:15-21

50:15-17

The Brothers Deceive Yoseph To Gain Forgiveness

- **50:15** “He will return to us all **the evil we repaid him!**”
- **50:17** “Yoseph wept as they spoke to him”

50:18

- “His brothers fell before him and said, ‘We are your servants!’”

50:19-21

Yoseph Is Honest With His Brothers and Forgives Them

- **50:20** **“You planned evil against me,** but Elohim planned good ... to save many lives!”

Genesis 50:22-26

50:22-23

- **Yoseph stays in Egypt and lives for 110 years**

50:24-25

Yoseph Anticipates a “Going Up” for His Future Family and for His Bones

- **50:24** **“He will bring up you all from this land”**
- **50:25** **“You will bring up my bones from this place”**

50:26

- **Yoseph dies at 110 years, and is placed in a box in Egypt**

Genesis 49:29-50:26. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

We have come to the end of the final literary unit in the Genesis scroll. Notice that it has been given a symmetrical three-part design.

1. On the outer ends, we have the parallel deaths of a father and a son, Yaaqov and Yoseph. Yaaqov asks for a burial in Canaan. And after his death, the narrative focuses on the elaborate funeral procession. On the other end comes Yoseph’s request for a burial in Canaan, and the narrative focuses on the future “ascent” out of Egypt into Canaan, followed by his death.
 - This brings the themes of the Eden story in [Genesis 2-3](#) toward their resolution: The exile of Adam and Eve from Eden resulted in death for all their descendants. Here, the deaths of Yaaqov and Yoseph end with a hope for a “going up” of their bones and bodies to reside in the “cave of Makpelah.”
2. In the center is a story of Yoseph’s final act of reconciliation and forgiveness toward his brothers.

- This brings the themes of Genesis 1-4 to their resolution: The older snake was not chosen for rule, but the humans were. Parallel to this, the older Cain was not chosen for the blessing, but his younger brother Abel was. But in this story, instead of that chosen-status evoking anger and murder, Yoseph uses his special status to become an image of divine forgiveness.

Yaaqov's Second Request to be Buried in Canaan

29 And **he commanded** them,
and said to them,
"I am about **to be gathered to my people**."

A **Bury** me with **my fathers** ,
in the cave which is **in the field** of **Ephron the Hittite**,

B 30 **in the cave** which is **in the field of Makpelah** (= "doubling")
which is opposite the face of Mamre in the land of Canaan,
which field Avraham **purchased** from **Ephron the Hittite** for a **burial**-possession.

A 31 There they **buried** **Avraham and Sarah** his wife,
there they **buried** **Yitzhaq and Rivqah** his wife,
there I **buried** **Le'ah** .

B' 32 **The field** **purchased**,
along **with the cave** which is in it,
from the **sons of Heth**."

33 And Ya'akov **finished commanding** his sons,
and **he gathered** his feet into the bed,
and he expired, and **he was gathered to his people**.

50:1 And Yoseph fell upon the face of his father,
and he **wept** over him,
and he kissed him.

2 And Yoseph commanded his servants **the healers (הרפאים)** to **embalm** his father,

and **the healers (הרפאים)** **embalmed** Yisra'el.

³ And they fulfilled for him **forty days**,

because this is how the days of the **embalmers** were fulfilled.

Then **Egypt** **wept** for him for **seventy days**.

A ⁴ And the days of **weeping** for him passed on,
and Yoseph said to the house of Phar'oh, saying,

"If, **please**, I have found favor in your eyes,
speak, **please**, in to ears of Phar'oh, saying,

⁵ 'My father made me **swear an oath**, saying,

"Look, I am about to die.

B In my **burial-grave** which I dug for myself in the land of Cana'an,
bury me there."

And now, **may I go up**, **please**,
so I can **bury** my father,
and so I can return."

B A' ⁶ **And Phar'oh said**,
"**Go up** and **bury** your father,
just as he made you **swear an oath**."

⁷ And Yoseph **went up** to **bury** his father,
and they **went up** with him,

a **all the servants of Phar'oh**,

b **the elders** of his house,

a' and **all the elders of the land of Egypt**,

a ⁸ and **all the house** of Yoseph,

b and his brothers,

a' and **the house** of his father.

Only their children and their flocks and their herds did they leave in the land of Goshen.

⁹ And they **went up** with him, both chariots and horsemen,
and the camp was **heavy, very much**.

¹⁰ And they came to **the threshing floor of the thorn (= "Goren-Ha'atad")**,

and they **wept** there a **great and heavy weeping**, **very much**,

and they **performed grieving** for their father, for **seven days**.

¹¹ And **the inhabitant of the land, the Cana'anite**, saw the **grieving** at **the threshing floor of the thorn**,
and they said,

"This is a **heavy** **grieving** for Egypt!"
For this reason, its name is called,
"**Grief** of **Egypt**" [= "Evel-Mitsrayim"]
which is across the Jordan.

12 And his sons did for him just as **he commanded** them,

13 and his sons carried him to the land of Cana'an,
and they **buried** him **in the cave** of **the field of Makpelah** (= "doubling"),
which field Avraham **purchased** for a **burial**-possession,
from **Ephron the Hittite**, opposite the face of Mamre.

14 And Yoseph returned to Egypt,
he and his brothers
and all those who went up with him to **bury** his father,
after he **buried** his father.

Genesis 49:29-50:14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Gathered With the Ancestors in the Cave of Makpelah

In this story, Yaaqov approaches his own death and requests that he be buried in the land of his ancestors in a specific cave in the field of Makpelah. This refers back to the only piece of land that Abraham ever purchased and owned, as recounted in Genesis 23.

This story assumes a knowledge of the Eden hyperlinks in that story.

Death, Paradise, and the Passing of the Righteous

The story of Sarah's burial is a full-scale replay of the core themes at work in the garden of Eden story. Through wordplays, hyperlinks, and narrative analogies, Abraham's loss of Sarah is compared to both the loss of eternal life in Eden and to the hope of God's promise to restore life.

The Death of the Beloved by the Sacred Tree in Genesis 23

After Abraham's great act of faithfulness, we're told that his beloved wife dies near the sacred tree that Abraham had encamped by all the way back in chapter 14. The design of this story emphasizes the special importance of this location, by repeating the mention of Hebron in the opening and closing of the chapter.

Gen. 23:1-3

And Sarah died
in Qiryath-'Arba' (**this is Hebron**),
in the land of Canaan .

Gen. 23:4-16

Abraham negotiates the purchase of the burial plot

Gen. 23:17, 19

which was in **Makpelah**,
which was facing **Mamre**,
the field and the cave which is in it,
and all the trees which are in the field,
which are in all the surrounding border.

...

Now, after this, Abraham **buried** Sarah his wife,
in **the cave of the field of Makpelah**,
which was facing **Mamre** (**this is Hebron**),
in the land of Canaan .

Gen. 13:18

Then Abram moved his tent and
came and dwelt by **the oaks of Mamre**, **which are in Hebron** ,
and there he built an altar to the Lord.

Gen. 14:13

Now he was living by **the oaks of Mamre** the Amorite, brother of Eshcol and brother of Aner, and these were allies with Abram.

Gen. 18:1

Now the Lord appeared to him
by **the oaks of Mamre**, while he
was sitting at the tent door in the
heat of the day.

Oaks of Mamre in Genesis 13-23. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The narrative highlights that when Abraham was living near Hebron/Mamre, it is by trees that he lived, worshipped, and met with God. This is a clear Eden motif because Abraham and Sarah are presented as a new Adam and Eve living in the promised garden land and communing with God by the trees of Hebron.

Sadly, the wife of the new Adam eventually dies by the sacred trees of Mamre. This is a vivid and potent image that recalls the woman eating from the tree that leads to death.

But it is also by the sacred trees of Mamre/Hebron that Sarah is buried.

Ephron = "Dusty," and the Hope of Eternal Life

The name of Abraham's Hittite negotiating partner is Ephron, from the Hebrew word for "dust" (*'aphar* / עפר). This creates the ironic image of Abraham bartering with Dusty to ensure a place of rest for his beloved as she returns to the dust.

Recall that "death unto the dust" was a key image from the Eden narrative that's associated with death.

Genesis 3:19 NASB*

By the sweat of your face you will eat bread,
until you return to the ground,
because from it you were taken;
for you are **dust** (*'aphar*)
and to **dust** (*'aphar*) you shall return.

The Cave of Makpelah/“Naked Pair”

Each of the words “cave” and “Makpelah” have rich wordplay associations with the Eden story.

“Cave” (*me’arah* / מערה) in Hebrew literally means “place of exposure/nakedness”. This Hebrew noun is related to two root words spelled with similar letters that both mean “to be exposed, naked”

1. ערר: *‘arar*, see [Isaiah 32:11](#).
2. עור: *‘ur*, see [Habakkuk 3:9](#), where it is spelled with the same letters as “nakedness” from [Genesis 2:25](#).

Genesis 2:25 Instructor’s Translation

And they were **naked** (*‘arum*, ערום) and they were not ashamed.

- [Genesis 23:9](#): “Cave”, Heb. *me’arah* (מערה)

“Makpelah” is an odd place name that means “doubling” or “pair.”

- The root is *kaphal* (כפל), which means “to be doubled” or “paired” (see examples of the verb in [Exod. 26:9](#); [Ezek. 21:19](#)).
- The meaning of Makpelah as “pair” or “double” is attested early in the history of Jewish interpretation, as the Greek Septuagint translators rendered this word with διπλούς, “twin” or “paired.”

When these curious words are combined, the name of this place is “The Nakedness of the Pair.” This is a clever reference back to the moment when Adam and Eve violate God’s command, eat from the forbidden fruit, and then realize that “the two of them are naked” ([Gen. 2:24-25](#) and [3:6-7](#)).

The Burial Plot as Abraham’s Mini-Eden

The description of the cave and the burial plot in [Genesis 23:17-18](#) is repetitious and unnecessarily wordy, as it repeats vocabulary from earlier in the chapter. Upon closer inspection, however, these repetitions seem intentional and create a series of hyperlinks back to earlier moments in the Abraham narrative where the promised land was set on analogy to Eden.

Genesis 23:17-18	Hyperlinks to Earlier Genesis Narratives
Gen. 23:17-18 And it was transferred, the field of Ephron (עפרון) which is by Makpelah, which is in front of Mamre (לפני ממרא)	Gen. 13:10-11 Lot lifted up his eyes and saw all the valley of the Jordan, all watered ... like the garden of God, before Yahweh destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah . And Lot chose for himself all the valley of the Jordan ... and they separated (פרד). Gen. 13:14-15, 18
Genesis 23’s Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 23:17-18

Hyperlinks to Earlier Genesis Narratives

Yahweh said to Abram after Lot **separated** (פרד) from him, “Lift up your eyes and see ... north, south, east, west ... I give it to you and your seed forever, and I will make your seed like the dust (עפר) of the earth.” And Abram tented and dwelt among the **oaks of Mamre** .

*In Genesis 13, Lot’s choice of Sodom as a false-Eden was set in contrast to Avraham’s choice of the promised land, specifically “the oaks of Mamre” which is God’s gift of Eden to Avraham.

the field and the cave which is in it, **and all the trees which are in** (כל העץ אשר ב-) the field

Gen. 1:29

And God said to the human, “Behold I have given to you every plant bearing seed which is on the face of the land, **and all the trees which are in it** (כל העץ אשר ב).”

Gen. 2:9

And Yahweh caused to sprout from the ground **all the trees** (כל עץ) that are desirable to look at

which is in all its border around (בכל ... סביב) to Avraham as a possession (למקנה) in the eyes of the sons of Heth, with all who enter the gate of his city.

Gen. 2:10-14

And a river went out from Eden **to water** (Hiph. שקה) the garden, and from there it **separated** (פרד) ... the Pishon it **went all around** (סבב) ... the Gihon **it went all around** (סבב) ...

Gen. 10:15, 19

And Canaan bore Sidon his firstborn and Heth. ... And the **border** of the Canaanite was from Sidon as you go ... to **Sodom and Gomorrah** .

Genesis 23’s Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Abraham’s burial plot is described as a tiny refuge for the “naked pair” that is located in the middle of a field filled with trees, namely the sacred trees of Mamre. One couldn’t ask for a more rich and creative set of allusions back to the garden of Eden.

Reflection Question

How is the burial cave in the field of Makpelah connected to the garden of Eden and to the hope of resurrection?